- **An Eastern Catholic note.** The Rosary is a Latin-Rite devotion, widely loved in the East. Its closest analogues are the **Jesus Prayer** with the chotki, the **Akathist Hymn** to the Mother of God, and the **Paraklesis**, which honour the same Incarnation in another form.

The Rosary in the Church's Teaching

The Rosary is a devotional practice, not a liturgical rite, and the Church commends it without obliging anyone to pray it. Pope St. Paul VI's apostolic exhortation *Marialis Cultus* (1974) set out its biblical and liturgical foundations and warned against reducing it to a mechanical repetition of formulas. Pope St. John Paul II's apostolic letter *Rosarium Virginis Mariae* (2002) added the Luminous Mysteries and called the Rosary "the compendium of the Gospel." The Catechism treats the Rosary as a form of popular piety and a way of meditating on the mysteries of Christ (CCC 2678, 2708).

Under the Church's current norms a plenary indulgence is granted to those who recite the Rosary in a church or oratory, in a family, or in a religious community or association of the faithful, and a partial indulgence for reciting it elsewhere, the usual conditions of confession, Communion, and prayer for the Pope being observed. The Feast of Our Lady of the Rosary on 7 October keeps the Church's gratitude for the deliverance of Christendom at Lepanto in 1571.

A Note on These Texts

The prayers printed here are the traditional devotional texts of the Latin Rite; none of them is required for the Rosary's validity, since it is not a sacrament. The Fatima Prayer comes from the apparitions at Fatima (1917), which the Church has approved as worthy of belief, though private revelation adds nothing to the deposit of faith. The assignment of the Luminous Mysteries to Thursday follows the custom established after Pope St. John Paul II's apostolic letter *Rosarium Virginis Mariae* (2002). The Litany of Loreto is traditionally recited after the Rosary in many places.

How to Pray the Holy Rosary

The Prayers, the Beads, and the Twenty Mysteries

Prayer Before the Rosary

```
Queen of the Holy Rosary,
Thou didst deign to come to Fatima to reveal to the three shepherd
children the treasures of grace hidden in the Rosary.
Inspire my heart with a sincere love of this devotion,
in order that by meditating on the Mysteries of our Redemption which are
recalled in it,
I may be enriched by its fruits and obtain peace for the world,
the conversion of sinners and of Russia,
and the graces which I ask of Thee in this Rosary.
(Here mention your request.) I ask this for the greater glory of God,
for Thine own honor, and for the good of souls,
especially for my own.
Amen.
```

The Beads and the Order of Prayer

A standard Dominican Rosary has five parts: the **crucifix**, one **large bead**, **three small beads**, a **centerpiece**, and a **loop of five decades**.

1. **At the crucifix.** Make the Sign of the Cross and recite the Apostles' Creed.
2. **On the first large bead.** Pray the Our Father.
3. **On the three small beads.** Pray three Hail Marys, offered for an increase of Faith, Hope, and Charity.
4. **Before the centerpiece.** Pray the Glory Be.
5. **At the centerpiece.** Announce the First Mystery with the traditional formula — *"The First Joyful Mystery, the Annunciation."* — then pray the Our Father.
6. **On the ten small beads of the decade.** Pray one Hail Mary on each bead, meditating on the Mystery and its fruit.
7. **At the end of the decade.** Pray the Glory Be, then the Fatima Prayer.
8. **On the single large bead.** Announce the next Mystery and pray the Our Father; repeat steps 6 and 7 for the second, third, fourth, and fifth decades.
9. **At the centerpiece after the fifth decade.** Pray the Hail, Holy Queen and the Concluding Prayer; many add the Memorare of St. Bernard here.
10. **Close.** Make the Sign of the Cross, and, if desired, pray the Prayer to Saint Michael the Archangel.

The Sign of the Cross

```
In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.
```

The fruits of the mysteries. Older rosary manuals name a fruit for each Mystery, asked for while the decade is prayed — humility at the Annunciation, patience under the Cross, faith at the Resurrection. These are a devotional association, not Church doctrine, and no one is bound to keep them.

- **The Annunciation** — humility.
- **The Visitation** — charity toward one's neighbour.
- **The Nativity** — poverty of spirit.
- **The Presentation** — obedience.
- **The Finding in the Temple** — zeal for the glory of God.
- **The Baptism in the Jordan** — fidelity to the promises of Baptism.
- **The Wedding at Cana** — trust in Our Lady's intercession.
- **The Proclamation of the Kingdom** — conversion of heart.
- **The Transfiguration** — desire for holiness.
- **The Institution of the Eucharist** — love of the Blessed Sacrament.
- **The Agony in the Garden** — conformity to the will of God.
- **The Scourging at the Pillar** — mortification of the flesh.
- **The Crowning with Thorns** — courage under contempt.
- **The Carrying of the Cross** — patience in tribulation.
- **The Crucifixion** — perseverance to the end.
- **The Resurrection** — faith.
- **The Ascension** — hope.
- **The Descent of the Holy Spirit** — love of God.
- **The Assumption** — a happy death.
- **The Coronation** — final perseverance.

Notes for the One Praying

- **The Rosary is a meditation, not a recitation only.** The words are the rhythm; the Mystery is the subject. If the mind wanders, return gently to the scene of the Mystery rather than to the words.
- **The body may pray too.** Customs differ — kneeling for the first decade, standing, or walking; holding the beads in the left hand and tracing them with the right; bowing at the *Gloria Patri*. None of this is prescribed, and none of it is required.
- **The family Rosary** follows the same order, with one member leading and the rest answering; the Our Father, Hail Mary, and Glory Be may be divided verse by verse.

4. **The Fourth Luminous Mystery, the Transfiguration** — Jesus is transfigured on Mount Tabor before Peter, James, and John, His face shining like the sun (*Matthew 17:1–8*).

5. **The Fifth Luminous Mystery, the Institution of the Eucharist** — at the Last Supper Jesus offers His Body and Blood under the signs of bread and wine, establishing the New Covenant (*Matthew 26:26–29*).

The Sorrowful Mysteries — Tuesday and Friday.

1. **The First Sorrowful Mystery, the Agony in the Garden** — Jesus prays in deep anguish at Gethsemane on the eve of His Passion, submitting His will to the Father (*Luke 22:39–46*).

2. **The Second Sorrowful Mystery, the Scourging at the Pillar** — Pilate orders Jesus to be bound to a pillar and brutally beaten (*John 19:1*).

3. **The Third Sorrowful Mystery, the Crowning with Thorns** — Roman soldiers weave a crown of thorns and mockingly place it on Jesus' head (*Matthew 27:27–31*).

4. **The Fourth Sorrowful Mystery, the Carrying of the Cross** — Jesus carries His heavy wooden cross through the streets of Jerusalem up to Calvary (*John 19:16–17*).

5. **The Fifth Sorrowful Mystery, the Crucifixion** — Jesus is nailed to the cross and dies after three hours of agonizing suffering (*Luke 23:33–49*).

The Glorious Mysteries — Sunday and Wednesday.

1. **The First Glorious Mystery, the Resurrection** — Jesus rises gloriously from the dead on the third day, conquering sin and death (*Matthew 28:1–10*).

2. **The Second Glorious Mystery, the Ascension** — Jesus ascends bodily into Heaven forty days after His Resurrection to take His place at the right hand of the Father (*Acts 1:1–11*).

3. **The Third Glorious Mystery, the Descent of the Holy Spirit** — the Holy Spirit descends as tongues of fire upon Mary and the Apostles in the Upper Room on Pentecost (*Acts 2:1–41*).

4. **The Fourth Glorious Mystery, the Assumption** — at the end of her earthly life the Blessed Virgin Mary is taken body and soul into Heaven by God (*CCC 966*).

5. **The Fifth Glorious Mystery, the Coronation** — Mary is crowned by her Son as Queen of Heaven and Earth, surrounded by all the choirs of angels (*Revelation 12:1*).

Prayed in common, the Rosary is led by one voice: the leader announces each Mystery, and all answer the Our Father, the Hail Marys, and the Glory Be together; prayed alone, a short silence before each decade serves the same end.

The Apostles' Creed

```
I believe in God, the Father almighty,
Creator of heaven and earth,
and in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord,
who was conceived by the Holy Spirit,
born of the Virgin Mary,
suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, died and was buried;
He descended into hell;
on the third day He rose again from the dead;
He ascended into heaven,
and is seated at the right hand of God the Father almighty;
from there He will come to judge the living and the dead.
I believe in the Holy Spirit,
the holy catholic Church,
the communion of saints,
the forgiveness of sins,
the resurrection of the body,
and life everlasting. Amen.
```

The Our Father

```
Our Father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be Thy name;
Thy kingdom come;
Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread;
and forgive us our trespasses
as we forgive those who trespass against us;
and lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil. Amen.
```

The Hail Mary

```
Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord is with thee;
blessed art thou among women,
and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus.
Holy Mary, Mother of God,
pray for us sinners,
now and at the hour of our death. Amen.
```

The Glory Be

```
Glory be to the Father, and to the Son, and to the Holy Spirit.
As it was in the beginning, is now, and ever shall be,
world without end. Amen.
```

The Fatima Prayer

```
O my Jesus, forgive us our sins,
save us from the fires of hell;
lead all souls to Heaven,
especially those in most need of Thy mercy. Amen.
```

The Hail, Holy Queen

```
Hail, holy Queen, Mother of mercy, our life, our sweetness, and our hope.
To thee do we cry, poor banished children of Eve.
To thee do we send up our sighs, mourning and weeping in this valley of
tears.
Turn then, most gracious Advocate, thine eyes of mercy toward us,
and after this our exile, show unto us the blessed fruit of thy womb,
Jesus.
O clement, O loving, O sweet Virgin Mary.

V. Pray for us, O holy Mother of God.
R. That we may be made worthy of the promises of Christ.
```

The Concluding Prayer

```
Let us pray.

O God, whose only-begotten Son,
by His life, death, and resurrection,
has purchased for us the rewards of eternal life,
grant, we beseech Thee,
that meditating upon these mysteries
of the Most Holy Rosary of the Blessed Virgin Mary,
we may imitate what they contain
and obtain what they promise,
through the same Christ our Lord. Amen.
```

The Memorare of St. Bernard

```
Remember, O most gracious Virgin Mary,
that never was it known that anyone who fled to thy protection,
implored thy help,
or sought thine intercession was left unaided.
Inspired by this confidence, I fly unto thee,
O Virgin of virgins, my mother; to thee do I come,
before thee I stand, sinful and sorrowful.
O Mother of the Word Incarnate, despise not my petitions,
but in thy mercy hear and answer me.
Amen.
```

The Prayer to Saint Michael the Archangel

```
Saint Michael the Archangel, defend us in battle.
Be our protection against the wickedness and snares of the devil.
May God rebuke him, we humbly pray; and do Thou,
O Prince of the Heavenly Host,
by the Divine Power of God, cast into hell
satan and all the evil spirits,
who roam throughout the world seeking the ruin of souls. Amen.
```

The Twenty Mysteries

Each Mystery is announced before the Our Father with the traditional formula — **"The [ordinal] [set] Mystery, the [name]."** The common custom is the **Joyful** on Monday and Saturday, the **Luminous** on Thursday, the **Sorrowful** on Tuesday and Friday, and the **Glorious** on Sunday and Wednesday; prayed in this rhythm, the whole life of Christ passes before the mind each week.

The Joyful Mysteries — Monday and Saturday.

1. **The First Joyful Mystery, the Annunciation** — the Archangel Gabriel announces to Mary that she will conceive the Son of God (*Luke 1:26–38*).
2. **The Second Joyful Mystery, the Visitation** — Mary visits her cousin Elizabeth, who is pregnant with John the Baptist (*Luke 1:39–56*).
3. **The Third Joyful Mystery, the Nativity** — Jesus Christ, the Savior of the world, is born in a stable in Bethlehem (*Luke 2:1–21*).
4. **The Fourth Joyful Mystery, the Presentation** — Mary and Joseph present the infant Jesus in the Temple in accordance with the Law of Moses (*Luke 2:22–38*).
5. **The Fifth Joyful Mystery, the Finding in the Temple** — after three days of searching, Mary and Joseph find the twelve-year-old Jesus teaching the scholars (*Luke 2:41–52*).

The Luminous Mysteries — Thursday.

1. **The First Luminous Mystery, the Baptism in the Jordan** — Jesus is baptized by John, the Holy Spirit descends upon Him like a dove, and the Father proclaims Him His beloved Son (*Matthew 3:13–17*).
2. **The Second Luminous Mystery, the Wedding at Cana** — at Mary's request Jesus performs His first public miracle, turning water into wine (*John 2:1–12*).
3. **The Third Luminous Mystery, the Proclamation of the Kingdom** — Jesus preaches the Gospel, announces the Kingdom of God, and calls all to repentance (*Mark 1:14–15*).